

Auburn - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | SEC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Top-30 underlying quality with a credible defensive floor, but unusually high transition risk around the offensive line, receiving corps and defensive front.
Preseason consensus	others receiving votes (3 points) · SEC media 12th · No. 26
Returning production	57% (No. 48) overall · Off. 56% (No. 61) · Def. 58% (No. 44)
Primer power rating	+11.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.4 wins · most likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↑ - Modestly better, but less stable than the headline model rank suggests
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Auburn should be a tempo-oriented offense built around confirmed starter QB Byrum Brown, RB Jeremiah Cobb and a reassembled transfer-heavy supporting cast, with Joel Gordon making the game-day calls.

Bottom line: Auburn has top-30 model strength and enough defensive credibility to reach bowl comfort, but the ceiling depends on whether the imported offense and reconstructed lines become functional before an unforgiving SEC middle stretch.

Beats expectations if: QB Byrum Brown accelerates the transition, the new OL coalesces, and the remade defensive front preserves enough of 2025's efficiency.

Disappoints if: OL combinations stay unstable, the new WR hierarchy cannot replace lost volume, and front-seven/secondary attrition drives defensive regression.

Five things to remember

- Coaching:** QB Byrum Brown is the confirmed QB1, and Joel Gordon is Auburn's game-day offensive play-caller.
- Linebackers:** LB Xavier Atkins is the roster's clearest proven star: 84 tackles, 17 TFL and nine sacks in 2025.
- 2025 baseline:** The 2025 defense was legitimately strong-opponent-adjusted defense No. 11, rush defense No. 10 and defensive success rate No. 17-but several of the players who built that baseline are gone.
- Offensive line:** The OL and WR rooms are major reconstruction projects: multiple 2025 starters reached the NFL or transferred.
- Schedule pressure:** SP+ ranks Auburn No. 26, but SEC media picked the Tigers 12th and the schedule is No. 16, including a Tennessee-Georgia-LSU-Ole Miss gauntlet and a road Iron Bowl.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	5-7 (1-7 SEC)	● Poor
Scoring	26.8 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	373.9 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	176.8 YPG · 4.7 YPC	● Good / above average
Pass efficiency	6.53 YPA · 11 TD / 4 INT	● Below average
Third downs	39.2%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	20.7 PPG allowed	● Very good
Total defense	329.2 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	99.3 YPG · 2.9 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	229.8 YPG · 7.24 YPA · 15 TD allowed	● Average / mixed

Auburn looked more competitive than 5-7 on defense: an elite run defense and strong overall yardage prevention were real strengths. The offense was more ordinary, with a productive run game but weak passing efficiency.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+1.58 · No. 58	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	+0.018 · No. 61	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	44.6% · No. 46	● Good / above average
Off. explosive-play rate	11.6% · No. 80	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	16.4% · No. 92	● Below average
Opp.-adjusted defense	+7.91 · No. 11	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.114 · No. 22	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	36.7% · No. 17	● Very good
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	10.1% · No. 29	● Very good
Havoc created	16.3% · No. 53	● Average / mixed

Advanced-stat read: Auburn's 2025 defense was much closer to elite than the 5-7 record suggests: opponent-adjusted defense No. 11, defensive EPA No. 22, success rate No. 17 and explosive prevention No. 29.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	♦ Alex Golesh - new external from USF HC	● ↔ Resets the program around Golesh’s USF model; upside comes with normal Year 1 transition risk.
OC / play-caller	♦ Joel Gordon - new external from USF; confirmed game-day offensive play-caller	● ↑ Auburn’s clearest pathway to offensive improvement is role clarity plus continuity with QB Brown and the imported staff.
Co-OC / WR	♦ Kodi Burns - new external from USF	● ↔ Burns supports a familiar imported offensive structure, but the WR room itself is being rebuilt.
DC / Co-DC	♦ DJ Durkin / Tim Banks - Durkin retained; Banks new external; defensive game-day caller unresolved	● ↔ Retaining Durkin preserves leadership from a strong 2025 defense while Banks adds a new co-coordinator layer.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ QB Byrum Brown	South Florida	● ↑ Confirmed QB1 with continuity in the broader Golesh/Gordon offensive context.
♦ WR Keshawn Singleton	South Florida	● ↔ Biletnikoff watchlist and positive camp mention make him a major-role candidate.
♦ WR Chas Nimrod	South Florida	● ↔ Positive second-scrimmage role evidence.
♦ C/IOL Cole Best	South Florida	● ↑ Twenty-three prior starts, including 20 at center.

Out	To	Loss
WR Eric Singleton Jr.	Florida	● ↓ Started all 12 games and led Auburn with 58 catches; a major volume loss.
WR Cam Coleman	Texas	● ↓ Twelve starts, 56 catches and a team-high 708 yards leave the receiver room.
WR/RS Malcolm Simmons	Texas Tech	● ↔ Meaningful receiving and punt-return production leaves, adding to the room-wide reset.
OT Xavier Chaplin	Florida State	● ↓ A 12-game starting left tackle leaves an OL already losing multiple starters to professional football.
C Connor Lew	NFL (Cincinnati), Round 4, No. 128	● ↓ Seven 2025 starts before injury and a fourth-round NFL selection remove proven center experience.

Offensive net: ● ↔ Higher offensive ceiling, lower continuity.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
♦ EDGE/DL Da'Shawn Womack	Ole Miss	● ↔ Current major front-role candidate who can absorb snaps.
♦ DB Kamari Todd	Chattanooga	● ↔ Eight prior starts and 50 tackles add useful experience to a secondary.

Out	To	Loss
EDGE Keldric Faulk	NFL (Tennessee), Round 1, No. 31	● ↓ Thirty-two career starts and a first-round NFL selection represent a major edge loss.
EDGE Keyron Crawford	NFL (Las Vegas), Round 3, No. 67	● ↓ All-12-game 2025 starter and third-round NFL pick leaves the edge group.
DL Bobby Jamison-Travis	NFL (N.Y. Giants), Round 6, No. 186	● ↓ All-12-game starting nose tackle departs as a sixth-round NFL selection.
DL Malik Blocton	LSU	● ↓ Eight 2025 starts leave the interior rotation.

Out	To	Loss
EDGE/DL Amaris Williams	Georgia	● ↔ Eleven-game front role with six TFL and two sacks leaves, compounding edge turnover.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Meaningful regression risk from an excellent 2025 baseline.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Tempo-oriented attack with a confirmed quarterback and imported offensive staff continuity.	QB Brown provides role certainty; RB Cobb gives a returning backfield centerpiece.	Protection and receiver hierarchy are being rebuilt simultaneously.
Defense	A Durkin-led defense trying to preserve a highly efficient 2025 structure around LB Xavier Atkins.	LB Atkins is an established impact player; S Champ Anthony is cleared.	The front loses multiple NFL/transfer starters and the secondary loses major-start volume.
Special teams	Known placekicker, unsettled surrounding specialist structure.	K Alex McPherson is current and recognized on the Lou Groza watchlist.	Long-snapper transition and no definitive primary punter in the relied sources.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B	● ↑	Medium-high	QB Byrum Brown is the confirmed QB1 and knows the imported offensive structure.
RB	● B	● ↔	Medium-high	RB Jeremiah Cobb is the returning major-role candidate with Maxwell recognition; depth has changed.
WR	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	Auburn replaces the two 12-start leading receivers plus additional volume.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Low	Preston Howard and Brandon Frazier are gone; TE Jake Johnson is a relevant addition.
OL	● C+	● ↓	Low	The line loses a 12-start left tackle and multiple starters to professional football.
DL/Edge	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	Major NFL and transfer losses create a substantial front replacement burden.
LB	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	LB Xavier Atkins is a national-level anchor.
Secondary	● B-	● ↓	Medium-low	S Champ Anthony and Rayshawn Pleasant provide recognizable returners, while DB Kamari Todd adds experience.
Special teams	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	K Alex McPherson is a recognized returning kicker.
Coaching	● B	● ↑	Medium-low	The imported offensive staff has internal continuity and a confirmed play-caller.
Overall	● B+	● ↑	Medium-low	SP+ No. 26 supports strong-Power-4/top-30 caliber.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Xavier Atkins	LB	● National star / defensive centerpiece	AP first-team All-America · Walter Camp first-team All-America · SEC Coaches first team · SEC Media first team	84 tackles, 17 TFL and nine sacks in 2025 plus first-team AP/Walter Camp All-America.
◆ Byrum Brown (TR: South Florida)	QB	● Established starter / transition key	Maxwell Award	Auburn’s confirmed QB1 is best positioned to make the imported offense functional quickly.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Jeremiah Cobb	RB	● Returning major-role back	Maxwell Award	He supplies rare offensive continuity in a room otherwise defined by new quarterback/receiver/line combinations.
◆ Keshawn Singleton (TR: South Florida)	WR	● Major-role transfer / WR1 candidate	Biletnikoff Award	Positive camp evidence and Biletnikoff recognition make him one of the most important answers.
◆ Cole Best (TR: South Florida)	C/IOL	● Experienced OL anchor candidate	Rimington Trophy	Twenty-three prior starts, 20 at center.
Champ Anthony	S	● Returning high-level secondary piece	SEC Media preseason third team	Cleared after prior leg injuries and carries preseason All-SEC recognition.
◆ Da'Shawn Womack (TR: Ole Miss)	EDGE/DL	● High-leverage transfer projection	-	Singled out after the second scrimmage.
Alex McPherson	K	● Proven specialist / stability point	Lou Groza Award · SEC Coaches third team · SEC Media third team	Current and available after illness, with Lou Groza and preseason All-SEC recognition.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Very difficult for a transition roster; the schedule offers early chances to stabilize before a brutal SEC middle run.
Difficulty	● 8/10 · SP+ SOS No. 16
Hardest stretch	at Tennessee → bye → at Georgia → LSU → at Ole Miss
Swing games	Baylor (neutral), Florida, Vanderbilt, at Mississippi State
Advantage	Southern Miss precedes the home Florida/Vanderbilt pair, and the lone bye lands between at Tennessee and at Georgia.
Expected	6.4 wins; likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Auburn can attract optimism from the new staff, a named QB and the brand.
Back them when	The price does not require immediate top-tier offensive efficiency and the opposing front is unlikely to overwhelm a new OL.
Fade/pass when	A premium line assumes the 2025 defense transfers intact despite major losses.
Key monitor	Final five OL and center alignment, WR pecking order beyond WR Keshawn Singleton/WR Chas Nimrod, front replacement production around EDGE/DL Da'Shawn Womack and other newcomers, secondary health.
Week 1 baseline	Auburn -7.5 vs. Baylor (neutral) · rating-only baseline; Auburn primer +11.5 minus Baylor primer +4.0; no home-field, matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Auburn -7.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Auburn has top-30 model strength, a confirmed QB1 in QB Byrum Brown and enough returning defensive talent to establish a solid floor. The offensive transition still depends on a reconstructed OL and a receiver hierarchy replacing heavy 2025 volume. The defense carries more regression risk after major front and secondary losses, making the SEC middle stretch the key test. The preseason baseline is **6.4 wins · likely 6-6** with SP+ SOS **No. 16**.

About this primer

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Last updated: August 25, 2026